

POLLINATION

Flowers reproduce by pollination – pollen being taken from one flower to another. Some plants self-pollinate, but animals, wind, and water often play a part.



ANIMAL
Many flowers contain nectar that attracts animals such as bees. While drinking the nectar the animal gets coated with pollen, which it carries to other flowers.



WIND
Some plants, such as grasses, rely on wind for pollination. They produce lots of pollen to increase the chances of it landing in the right places.



WATER
A small number of aquatic plants are pollinated by water. Pollen is released into the water and carried to other plants by water currents.



SELF
Some plants self-pollinate by either transferring pollen from the anther to the stigma of the same flower, or to another flower on the same plant.

FRUITS

Fruits are the parts of a plant that contain seeds. Some fruits change colour and become juicy when ripe, which makes them attractive to animals. If a fruit is eaten, its seeds pass through the animal's digestive tract and are dispersed in its droppings. Some types of fruit have wings or hooks and are carried on the wind or stuck in an animal's fur.



1 SEEDS AT BASE
After pollination, seeds form in this melon flower's ovary.



2 OVARY SWELLS
The flower petals fall away and the ovary begins to swell.



3 SMALL FRUIT
The skin hardens; the ovary is now a small fruit.



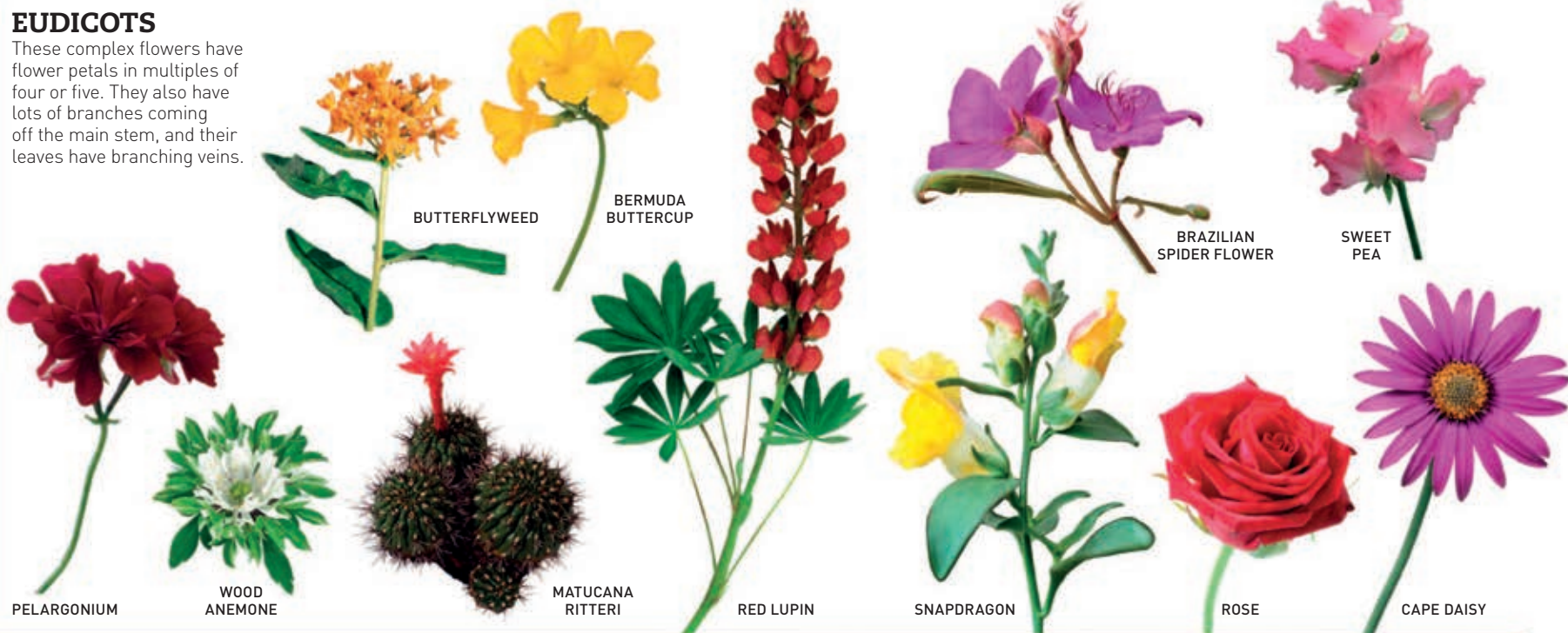
4 RIPENING
Over the growing season, the fruit gets bigger and ripens.



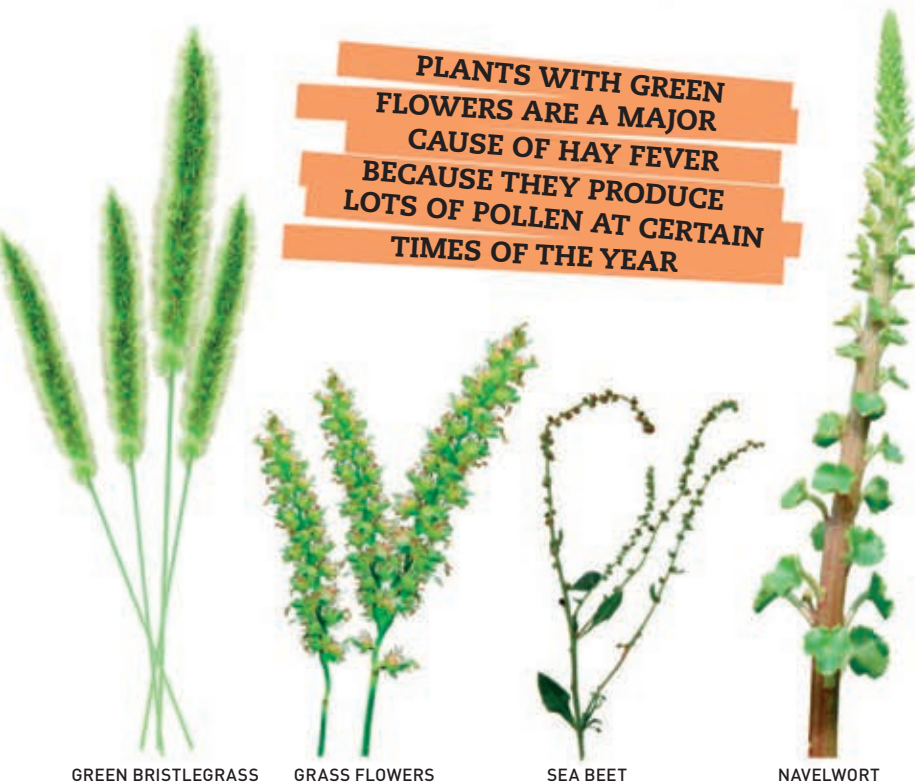
5 MATURE FRUIT
The melon is ripe. If an animal eats it the seeds will be dispersed.

EUDICOTS

These complex flowers have flower petals in multiples of four or five. They also have lots of branches coming off the main stem, and their leaves have branching veins.



PLANTS WITH GREEN FLOWERS ARE A MAJOR CAUSE OF HAY FEVER BECAUSE THEY PRODUCE LOTS OF POLLEN AT CERTAIN TIMES OF THE YEAR



THE GREAT PRETENDERS

Some flowers have evolved in ways that would make them at home in fairy tales. Among them are flowers that look like insects. Others smell of bad meat or the foul scent sprayed by skunks. Such strange adaptations have a good reason – they are tricks to attract pollinators.



RAFFLESIA
This is also known as the "corpse flower" because it smells like a rotten carcass. It has no roots or leaves, and lives off other plants, taking their nutrients and water.



BEE ORCHID
This flower has petals that look like a bee. Real bees are fooled into trying to mate with it, so they pick up and disperse the pollen.



WESTERN SKUNK CABBAGE
The tiny flowers are surrounded by a vivid yellow structure called a "spathe". Some insects love the skunky smell of this plant.



STINK LILY
The long black spike (spadix) on this plant stinks of rotten meat – which attracts flies hoping for a meal.